

The Alum Rock Trail Crew is a community-based volunteer group that works on trail maintenance and habitat restoration in the Park. We remove invasive plants so native ecosystems can thrive, as well as reducing fuel and fire danger. We are drawn together by a special connection to the Park and a shared interest in conservation and improving the visitor experience at San José's oldest park.

Get involved: Join us Monday and Wednesday mornings, or the second Saturday of each month.

Native plants support the park's ecosystem



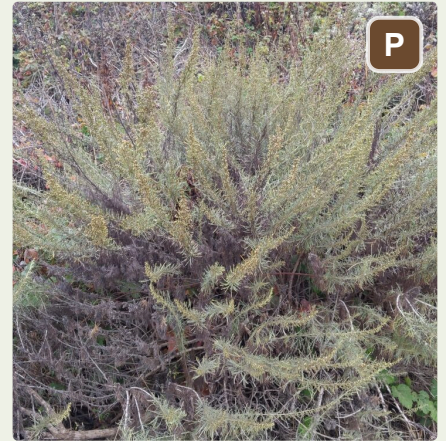
Oaks *Quercus* spp.

Evergreen coast live oaks and deciduous valley and blue oaks. These iconic trees anchor the whole ecosystem, feeding and sheltering more wildlife than almost any other native plant.



Coyote Brush *Baccharis pilularis*

A small-leaved evergreen shrub with fuzzy white seed heads in fall. It's a keystone species, hosting far more insects, birds, and other wildlife than most other native plants.



California Sagebrush *Artemisia californica*

A soft shrub with delicate, silvery grey-green foliage. Brushing the leaves releases a sage-like scent, making it easy to identify by smell alone.



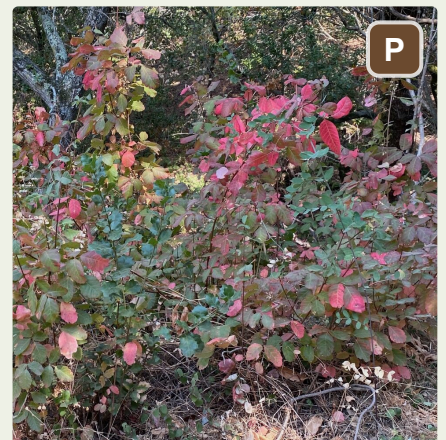
Vinegar Weed *Trichostema lanceolatum*

A low, sticky herb whose leaves smell strongly of vinegar when crushed. It's tough enough to keep blooming through the driest part of late summer, when little else is flowering.



Gumweed *Grindelia camporum*

A tall, branching plant with stiff, toothed leaves and yellow daisy-like flowers. Its buds fill with sticky white resin; butterflies visit the flowers and songbirds eat the seeds.



Poison Oak *Toxicodendron diversilobum*

Do not touch. Its oils cause an itchy rash in most people, but birds and deer rely on its berries and leaves. Look for its bright red color in fall.

Invasive plants targeted for removal



Milk Thistle *Silybum marianum*

A spiny plant with white-marbled leaves and purple flower heads. It spreads quickly by seed and crowds out natives, so pull it before it flowers and add it to compost.



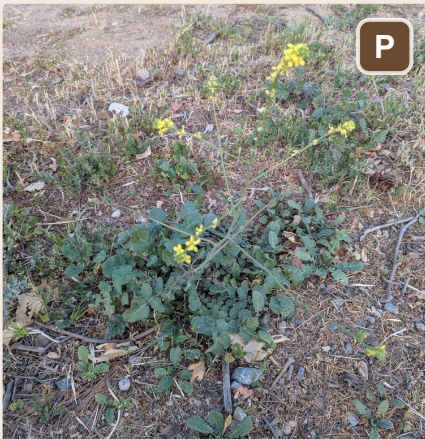
Italian Thistle *Carduus pycnocephalus*

A spiny plant with tall stalks and clustered pink-purple flowers. It forms dense stands that block trails and crowd out natives, so dig it up before it flowers.



White Horehound *Marrubium vulgare*

A plant with fuzzy, wrinkled grey-green leaves and a minty smell. It spreads aggressively along disturbed ground and regrows from its roots, so dig up the whole plant.



Mustard *Hirschfeldia incana*

A fast-spreading plant with small yellow flowers, abundant throughout the park. It regrows from its roots and can quickly dominate open ground, so dig up the whole plant.



Yellow Star Thistle *Centaurea solstitialis*

A plant with sharp yellow spines that favors disturbed trail edges. It's toxic to horses and spreads aggressively, so bag it for removal instead of composting.



Stinkwort *Dittrichia graveolens*

A sticky, strong-smelling plant that can cause allergic skin reactions on contact. It spreads readily along trails, so bag it for removal instead of composting.

A Annual — new plant each year (invasive: pull & compost)

P Perennial — regrows from roots (invasive: dig up fully)

! Bag & remove — too vigorous for compost piles to kill

? Not sure what you're seeing? Ask someone in a volunteer t-shirt!

Photos via iNaturalist: Coyote Brush © LSchare (she/her); California Sagebrush © Ryan Masters; Milk Thistle © Konstantinos Kalaentzis; Mustard © Amy; Yellow Star Thistle © Ken-ichi Ueda; all other photos © Kimberly Nicholls.